

card slots allow you to expand the memory up to 32GB.

Locked/unlocked. This is a really important factor to keep in mind when buying a dongle. Some telecom providers tie up with dongle manufacturers to bring out products known as locked dongles. These only work with that specific provider's SIM card. It is preferable to use a dongle that is unlocked because then you can find the telecom provider with the best connectivity and coverage, and use their SIM card. You will not be forced to stay with a provider that does not offer good service.

Dongles to watch out for

Which ones do you think should be at the top of your list? Let us take a look.

Best 3G dongle with Wi-Fi hotspot: **Huawei Power-Fi E8231.** Huawei Power-Fi E8231 hotspot-enabled data card is a bestseller on www.amazon.in. It can be used to connect up to ten devices with a hotspot. It provides support for 3G connectivity.

This dongle can even be plugged into a car charger or power mains. High-Speed Downlink Packet Access (HSDPA) speed is 21.6Mbps, and High-Speed Uplink Packet Access Speed (HSUPA) is 5.76Mbps. It also supports SMS. To manage your Wi-Fi connections, you can download Huawei Mobile Wi-Fi app from Google Play store. It allows you to monitor data usage as well as the battery life of the device.

Most affordable dongle: **ZTE MF190.** This 3G dongle from ZTE promises a download speed of 7.2Mbps and uplink speed of 5.76Mbps. It has a USB 2.0 interface.

The dongle has phonebook storage and supports SMS. However, it does not provide support for voice calling. It is equipped with a microSD card slot, which allows you to expand storage to 32GB.

High-performing 3G dongle: **D-Link DWP-157.** If you require a 3G dongle only for your laptop and do

not intend to create a Wi-Fi hotspot, then this device is good for you. It provides support for Evolved High Speed Packet Access (HSPA+) 3G technology, which means that it can provide a maximum downlink speed of 21Mbps and an uplink rate up to 5.76Mbps. It has phonebook storage and supports SMS as well. It has a microSD card slot that lets you expand the memory up to 32GB.

Dongle with voice-call support: **iBall Airway 21.0MP-58.** This dongle offers voice call feature in addition to high-speed connectivity, which means you can make phone calls using your laptop. It offers a HSDPA of 21Mbps and HSUPA of 5.76Mbps, and is compatible with 2G/3G GSM networks. It supports SMS and comes with a phonebook feature to store contacts conveniently.

In terms of expandable memory, it has a microSD card slot to expand the memory up to 32GB. This dongle can be used to create a Wi-Fi hotspot to connect multiple devices to the Internet. All you need to do is install iBall Soft AP app on your laptop.

High-speed 4G dongle: **Micromax MMX44L.** This 4G dongle from Micromax promises a HSDPA of 68Mbps and HSUPA of 17.8Mbps. It can be used to create a Wi-Fi hotspot for other devices to connect to the Internet. It has USB 2.0 interface, phonebook and SMS support but no voice call support. Its memory can be extended to 32GB with a microSD card.

Remember the network limitations

Some dongle manufacturers promise ultra-fast speeds, and this can seem very tempting. But do keep in mind that the dongle speed is limited by the network coverage in your area. 4G LTE networks are not available all over India, yet. Check about the available networks in your area before selecting a dongle, to make sure that you get the best service and speed, at all times. **EFY**

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